

# Official Public Health Advisory

Issued by: Australian Government Department of Health and Aged Care

Date: November 12, 2024

Subject: Updated Public Health Guidance and Mitigation Measures for Virus X (recently named Spok-24 Virus)

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## CURRENT SITUATION

The Australian Government, in consultation with state and territory health departments, is escalating its response to the ongoing **Virus SPOK-24 outbreak**. Given the **widespread community transmission in multiple cities, increasing hospitalizations, and confirmed international spread**, additional **public health measures** are being implemented to reduce transmission, protect vulnerable populations, and ease pressure on the healthcare system.

At this stage:

- **Community transmission is widespread in Brisbane, with cases increasing in Sydney, Melbourne, and other major cities.**
- **Hospitalizations continue to rise, and contact tracing capacity is exceeded in key outbreak areas.**
- **Domestic travel has declined significantly; international travel restrictions have been implemented by multiple countries.**
- **The WHO has declared Virus SPOK-24 a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC).**

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## UPDATED PUBLIC HEALTH RECOMMENDATIONS

To **reduce transmission and safeguard public health**, all **residents, businesses, and organizations** must **immediately** adhere to the following guidance:

### 1. WORK AND PUBLIC GATHERINGS

#### Work from Home:

- Employers are urged to **maximize remote working arrangements** wherever possible, especially in affected areas (Brisbane, Sydney, Melbourne).
- **Essential workers** (healthcare, emergency services, utilities, and logistics) must follow **strict workplace infection control measures** (mask use, distancing, symptom screening).

#### Avoid Non-Essential Gatherings:

- All **indoor gatherings over 50 people** are **strongly discouraged**, including social, religious, and professional events.

- **Bars, clubs, and entertainment venues** should adhere to **reduced capacity limits** to avoid crowding.

#### **High-Risk Settings:**

- **Aged care facilities, hospitals, and disability care homes** must **limit visitations** to essential visitors only.
- **Universities and schools** should **consider remote learning options only** if they experience local clusters.

## **2. PERSONAL PROTECTIVE MEASURES**

### **Mask-Wearing (in Affected Areas)**

- Recommended for **all individuals in crowded indoor spaces** (markets, transport hubs, events).

### **Physical Distancing & Hygiene**

- **Regular handwashing** with soap or use of **alcohol-based sanitizers** is strongly encouraged.
- **Cough and sneeze etiquette** must be followed—cover mouth/nose with elbow or tissue.

## **3. TRAVEL AND MOVEMENT RESTRICTIONS**

### **Domestic Travel Advisory**

- All **non-essential interstate travel** should be **postponed**.
- Travel **between Brisbane and other states** is **discouraged** unless absolutely necessary.
- **Airport and train stations** will implement **enhanced screening measures** in affected areas.

### **International Travel Restrictions**

- As of **November 11**, multiple countries—including the **USA, Europe, China, and New Zealand**—have **restricted travel to and from Australia** for humanitarian reasons only.
- **Australian citizens abroad** should contact embassies for **repatriation flights**.

## **4. WORKPLACE AND BUSINESS GUIDELINES**

### **Public Transport and Mobility**

- Public transport services **will continue**, but passengers **must wear masks** and follow distancing markers.

- **Peak-hour travel should be minimized** where possible (e.g., staggered shifts, remote work).
- Ride-sharing and taxis should **limit shared rides** and ensure vehicle ventilation.

## 5. HEALTHCARE AND TESTING

### COVID or flu-like Symptoms? Get Tested Immediately

- Anyone with **fever, cough, sore throat, fatigue, or difficulty breathing** should **self-isolate and get tested** for Virus SPOK-24.
- Testing **will be expanded** to include **more clinics in Melbourne, Sydney, and regional centers**.

### Hospitals & Clinics Under Strain

- **Non-urgent surgeries and elective procedures may be delayed** to prioritize respiratory illness cases.
- If you **require medical attention**, call ahead **before visiting hospitals or GPs** to avoid overcrowding.

### Support for Vulnerable Populations

- Special provisions for **elderly residents, people with disabilities, and those with pre-existing conditions** will be implemented, including **priority access to medical care and social support**.

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## GOVERNMENT ACTIONS

- **Emergency response measures expanded** across all states to strengthen **healthcare system readiness**.
- **Financial and economic support** for affected businesses, including wage subsidies and small business assistance programs.

The **National Cabinet is meeting regularly** to assess the evolving situation. Further updates will be provided as new information becomes available.

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## KEY MESSAGE FROM AUSTRALIAN CHIEF MEDICAL OFFICER

*"We understand that these measures are challenging, but they are necessary to **slow the spread of Virus X and protect our healthcare system**," said the **Australian Chief Medical Officer**.*

*"The actions we take now will determine how well we can contain this outbreak. Please follow the **guidelines**, look out for vulnerable members of our community, and stay informed through official channels."*

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## FURTHER INFORMATION & OFFICIAL UPDATES

For official updates, visit:

[\[www.health.gov.au\]](http://www.health.gov.au) (Australian Government Department of Health)

📞 **Coronavirus Health Information Line: [National Hotline Number]**

**Check local state health websites for specific guidance.**

This advisory will be updated as the situation evolves. **Please remain vigilant and follow public health recommendations.**

**END OF ADVISORY**

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